

# *swipe*

English

## Etymology

From earlier swip (with a short vowel), from Middle English swippen, swipen (“to move violently”), from Old English swipian, sweopian, swippan (“to scourge, strike, beat, lash”), from Proto-Germanic \*swipōną, \*swipjanaą (“to move”), from

Proto-Indo-European \*swey**b**- (“to bend, turn, swerve, sway, swing, sweep”).

Cognate with German *schwippen* (“to whip”), Danish *svippe* (“to smack; crack a whip”), Icelandic *svipa* (“to whip; move swiftly”). Related to sweep, swoop.

## Pronunciation

Audio (US)

(file)



■ Rhymes: -a**i**p

## Verb

**swipe** (*third-person singular simple present* **swipes**, *present participle* **swiping**, *simple*

*past and past participle **swiped***)

1. (transitive) To steal or snatch.

*Hey! Who **swiped** my lunch?*

■ **1968**, The Heart Is a Lonely Hunter,

00:48:18:

"Maybe I could swipe some  
Tintex from the five-and-dime."

2. (transitive) To scan or register by sliding something through a reader.

*He **swiped** his card at the door.*

3. (intransitive) To grab or bat quickly.

*The cat **swiped** at the shoelace.*

4. (intransitive) To interact with a touch screen by drawing one's finger rapidly across it.

***Swipe*** left to hide the toolbar.

## Coordinate terms

- (*to interact with a touch screen*): scroll

## Translations

|                                 |          |
|---------------------------------|----------|
| to snatch                       | [show ▼] |
| to slide through a reader       | [show ▼] |
| to grab quickly                 | [show ▼] |
| to interact with a touch screen | [show ▼] |

## Noun

**swipe** (countable and uncountable, plural swipes)

1. (countable) A quick grab, bat, or other motion with the hand or paw; A sweep.
2. (countable) A strong blow given with a sweeping motion, as with a bat or club.
3. (countable, informal) A rough guess; an estimate or swag.

*Take a **swipe** at the answer, even if you're not sure.*

4. (uncountable) Poor, weak beer or other inferior alcoholic beverage; rotgut.

- **1984**, Ronald T. Takaki, Pau Hana: Plantation Life and Labor in Hawaii, 1835-1920, ↑ISBN, page 134:

Woozy with **swipe** was the only way I could stay down with

patience for work.

- **1990**, Charles Langlas & James Ahia, The People of Kalapana, 1823-1950:  
JJ: Did a lot of people drink? KP:  
Down here, oh yeah, a lot of them  
made their own **swipe**, their own  
potato and pineapple **swipe**.
- **1998**, Gary Pak, Pak: A Ricepaper  
Airplane, [↑ISBN](#), page 73:  
Sung Wha knows it's pineapple  
**swipe** they are drinking. Hoping  
that they might sell him some of  
the stuff, he approaches them  
with the dollar bill out. One  
worker, sucking on a fat, wet stub

of a cigar, waves off the offer and shakes his head: no we aren't selling the **swipe**, the **swipe** is for us to drink and enjoy.

- **2012**, James Jones, The World War II Trilogy, ↑ISBN:

Only the nights—of sitting out in the moonlight drinking the horrible tasting **swipe** and talking, the thinking about women — remained unchanged.

## Anagrams

- pwise, wipes

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